

Forty Days at a Time

Lesson 24 — The road to revolution, 1977–1979

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain how Shi'i mourning ritual became a self-sustaining protest mechanism

2

Trace the escalation from January 1978's protests to the Shah's departure

3

Explain why casualty figures for this revolution remain genuinely disputed

4

Evaluate which single event, if any, made the Shah's overthrow inevitable

Grievances, accumulated over a quarter century

Lessons 22 and 23 built the foundation: a coup that discredited democracy, and reforms that alienated clergy and traditional elites alike. This lesson covers how those accumulated grievances finally erupted into an unstoppable movement.

An insulting article, January 1978

A government-linked newspaper, Ettela'at, published an article accusing the exiled Khomeini of being a foreign agent. Religious students in Qom staged protests in response; security forces opened fire, killing several. The pattern that would define the entire revolution had begun.

Forty days, and forty days again

Shi'i tradition marks forty days of mourning after a death. Each round of protest deaths produced, forty days later, a fresh mourning ceremony that itself became a mass protest — sometimes ending in further deaths, and a further forty-day cycle. Religious ritual, banned from being openly political, substituted for organised opposition the state could not simply outlaw.

The Cinema Rex fire, August 1978

A fire at Abadan's Cinema Rex killed around 400 people; while later investigation attributed it to Islamist arsonists, many Iranians at the time believed SAVAK had started it deliberately to discredit the opposition. Whichever the truth, the widespread belief itself fuelled nationwide outrage — a reminder that what people believe happened can shape events as powerfully as what actually did.

Black Friday, 8 September 1978

Under newly declared martial law, troops opened fire on demonstrators in Tehran's Jaleh Square, killing a still-disputed number of protesters. Widely remembered as the moment reconciliation between the Shah and the opposition became impossible, it triggered nationwide strikes that would soon paralyse the country entirely.

Oil workers strike, October 1978

Strikes spread from students and shopkeepers to Iran's vital oil sector, cutting national production by millions of barrels a day and crippling the government's main source of revenue — removing the Shah's economic room for manoeuvre just as political pressure peaked.

From military government to departure

A military government appointed in November 1978 failed to restore order; December's religious commemorations brought millions into the streets nationwide. On 16 January 1979, the Shah left Iran, officially “on vacation”, appointing Shapour Bakhtiar as prime minister — a government that would last only weeks.

1 February 1979: Khomeini comes home

After fourteen years in exile, Khomeini returned to Tehran to be greeted by millions of Iranians. Within ten days, on 11 February, the revolution was declared victorious and the monarchy formally abolished — ending 2,500 years of Iranian kingship.

How many actually died?

Khomeini himself claimed 60,000 people were “martyred” by the Shah's regime during the revolution. Careful historical analysis — including work by military historian Spencer Tucker — places the actual death toll for the 1978–79 period at somewhere between roughly 500 and 2,800, rejecting the 60,000 figure as significantly overstated for propaganda purposes. Whose figure you cite, and why, is itself a historiographical choice.

A full essay attempt

'Black Friday, more than any other single event, made the Shah's overthrow inevitable.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence about the mourning-cycle mechanism and the oil strikes
- Address the counter-argument that no single event alone determined the outcome

Key terms from today

Forty-day mourning cycle

The self-sustaining Shi'i ritual pattern that repeatedly renewed protest.

Bakhtiar government

The short-lived administration appointed just before the Shah's departure.

Black Friday

8 September 1978, the martial-law shooting widely seen as the point of no return.

Disputed casualty figures

The gap between Khomeini's claimed toll and historians' careful estimates.

What to remember

A newspaper insult in January 1978 set off a self-renewing cycle of mourning and protest that, reinforced by Black Friday's violence and crippling oil strikes, overwhelmed the Shah's government within a single year. Casualty figures for this period remain genuinely disputed, ranging from historians' careful estimates in the low thousands to Khomeini's own, much higher, claimed total.

Lesson 25 — Founding the Islamic Republic

Next lesson: how Khomeini turned a broad revolutionary coalition into a specifically clerical Islamic state — and what happened to his former allies along the way.